Week 7 Session 1

Week 7, Session 1 — Strategy, Ethics, and the Long View

IDSC 4101: Agentic AI for Business Applications

Session type: Lecture + Socratic discussion + capstone prep **Final exam:** Conceptual Exam 2 due before this session (released Week 6 Session 1) **Capstone:** Final demo + 3-slide pitch deck due before Session 2 (submitted via LMS)

SLIDE DECK

SLIDE 1 — Title Slide

Title: Where Is This Going — and What Does It Mean for You? **Subtitle:** AI Strategy, Ethics, and the Decisions That Will Define Your Career **Course:** IDSC 4101: Agentic AI for Business Applications | Week 7, Session 1

Speaker Notes: This is the last lecture session of the course. Tomorrow you present. Today we ask the biggest questions. Not "how does this tool work" — you know that. Not "how do businesses deploy this" — you know that too. Today's question is: what does all of this mean for the organizations you'll work in, the decisions you'll be responsible for, and the kind of professional you want to be? This is not a soft close. It's the hardest session of the course, because it asks you to hold genuine uncertainty — about technology, about ethics, about your own role — without resolving it artificially. I want you to leave today with better questions, not easy answers. Let's start.

SLIDE 2 — The Course in One Frame

Title: Seven Weeks — One Arc

Weeks 1–2: What is generative AI? What can it do, what can't it do, and what mental model do I need to use it well?

Weeks 3–4: How do businesses deploy AI at scale? What changes about workflows, functions, and decision-making when AI is embedded in operations? What is an agent, and how does it fail?

Weeks 5–6: How do I build with AI? What does a working agent look like, and how do I evaluate an AI product for strategy, risk, and responsible deployment?

Week 7: Now what?

Speaker Notes: The arc was deliberate. We started with personal tools because that's where intuition lives. We zoomed out to business processes because that's where most of your careers will begin. We went deeper into agentic systems because that's where most of the transformation — and most of the risk — is happening

right now. And we arrive here: the strategic and ethical questions that don't have clean answers, that require judgment rather than frameworks, and that you'll be navigating for the rest of your careers. The course gave you vocabulary, tools, and methods. Today is about developing the judgment to use them wisely.

SLIDE 3 — How Organizations Actually Make AI Decisions

Title: The Strategic Reality of AI Adoption

How it actually works (not how it's described in business press):

Pressure, then permission: Most AI adoption starts with competitive pressure ("our competitors are using this"), not strategic vision. A department lead sees a productivity gain, gets informal permission to pilot, and the pilot either succeeds and spreads or fails quietly. Formal strategy often follows adoption, not the reverse.

Pockets of capability, no coherent architecture: Most large organizations have AI tools scattered across teams — some teams using Copilot, some using custom GPT wrappers, some building agents, some still using legacy processes. There is rarely a coherent enterprise architecture for AI, especially in the first 2–3 years of adoption.

The governance lag: Technology adoption almost always outpaces governance. New AI tools get deployed before the data privacy policies are updated, before the HR implications are sorted, before the compliance team has reviewed the use case. The responsible AI frameworks we covered in Week 6 are written for a world where governance keeps pace. In practice, it usually doesn't.

The talent gap: Organizations are deploying AI faster than they're developing the human capability to evaluate and oversee it. The most valuable professionals in this environment are not the ones who can code AI — it's the ones who can ask the right questions about AI decisions, evaluate risk, manage governance gaps, and translate between technical teams and business leadership.

Speaker Notes: This slide is deliberately unromantic about how AI strategy actually gets made. Students are often taught strategy as a rational, top-down process. The reality of technology adoption is much messier: it's driven by champions, competitive pressure, and informal pilots. That's not a failure of management — it's how technology has always diffused through organizations. The implication for students is that their value will rarely come from knowing the technology better than the engineers. It will come from being able to bring order to the governance gap, ask the right evaluation questions, and make the case for responsible deployment practices to leaders who are moving fast and not thinking carefully enough about risk.

SLIDE 4 — The Talent Question: What Roles Are Actually Emerging?

Title: Where the Jobs Are — and What They Require

Emerging roles that didn't exist in their current form five years ago:

AI Product Manager: Owns the product roadmap for AI-powered features or AI-native products. Requires: deep user empathy, ability to evaluate AI capabilities and limitations, strong cross-functional communication between engineering and business, and judgment about responsible AI tradeoffs. Does not require coding — requires AI literacy at the level of this course.

AI Strategy Consultant: Helps organizations assess AI readiness, prioritize use cases, evaluate vendors, and design governance frameworks. Requires: the business function knowledge from Week 3, the deployment evaluation from Week 4 (failure modes, guardrails), and the responsible AI vocabulary from Week 6. Rapidly becoming a standard offering at major consulting firms.

AI Governance Analyst: Owns compliance, audit, and policy for AI deployments. Tracks regulatory developments (EU AI Act, sector-specific rules), maintains documentation of AI systems, and coordinates the human oversight mechanisms we discussed in Weeks 4–6. Requires: regulatory knowledge, documentation discipline, and the ability to ask hard questions about AI system behavior. This is the role that often gets created after the first compliance incident.

AI-Augmented Domain Specialist: A lawyer, accountant, marketer, or operations manager who uses AI tools to do their work faster, better, and at greater scale than peers who don't. This is not a new job title — it's an evolution of every existing role. The differential is AI literacy. Students who graduate with this literacy will outperform peers who don't within 18 months of starting their first job, across virtually every function.

Speaker Notes: Walk through these roles with specificity — students are making career decisions, and abstract observations about "AI changing jobs" are not useful to them. The AI-augmented domain specialist role is the most immediately relevant: it describes what most students will become within their first job, regardless of their concentration. The AI Product Manager and AI Strategy Consultant roles describe career paths that are now well-defined and actively hiring. The AI Governance Analyst role describes a role that is newly important and currently undersupplied — worth naming for students who are drawn to compliance, policy, or legal tracks.

SLIDE 5 — The Ethics Layer: What the Frameworks Don't Resolve

Title: Responsible AI Beyond the Checklist

What the frameworks cover well: - Bias and disparate impact: we have measurement tools and regulatory guidance - Data privacy: GDPR, CCPA, and sector-specific law give clear obligations - Security: threat models and mitigation techniques are well-established - Transparency: citation requirements, audit logs, explainability — these are designable

What the frameworks don't resolve:

The substitution question: When AI makes a human role obsolete — what is the organization's obligation to the displaced worker? This is not a legal question in most jurisdictions. It is a values question. Different companies answer it differently, and the answers are consequential.

The autonomy question: As agents become more capable, the question of where human judgment must be preserved — not for accuracy, but for accountability and dignity — becomes harder to answer. An AI can make a better lending decision than a loan officer on average. Should it? What is lost when no human is responsible for the decision?

The concentration question: AI capabilities are concentrated in a small number of companies and, increasingly, in AI systems owned by those companies. What are the implications of a world where economic decision-making infrastructure is controlled by a small number of very powerful AI systems? This is a question with no consensus answer — but students who will work at companies deploying these systems need to have thought about it.

Speaker Notes: These three questions don't have answers in the course materials because they don't have consensus answers anywhere. The purpose of naming them is not to resolve them but to ensure students carry them. The best professionals in AI deployment are the ones who ask these questions in the rooms where decisions are being made — and who push back when the answers are too easy. That kind of ethical presence is not about being obstructionist. It's about being the person who notices what others aren't looking at. —

SLIDE 6 — Where Is This Going? The Next 3–5 Years

Title: What to Expect — and How to Think About It

What is likely in the next 3–5 years:

Agentic AI becomes infrastructure: The agents we built in Week 5 as learning exercises will be production systems for most large organizations within 3 years. Not optional add-ons — embedded infrastructure, as foundational as email or ERP systems. The implication: the governance questions we discussed in Weeks 4 and 6 will become standard operational requirements, not leading-edge concerns.

Multi-modal AI becomes standard: Text-only AI is already giving way to systems that read images, listen to audio, interpret video, and act on physical sensors. The mental models from this course — goal, tools, memory, reasoning loop — still apply. The inputs and outputs get richer.

Personalization at scale becomes the norm: AI-native products that deliver individualized experiences — in education, healthcare, financial advice, customer service — will be the baseline expectation for new products and services. Products that don't personalize will feel like generic products of the past. The business model implications (data flywheel, outcome-based pricing) we covered in Week 6 will become dominant.

Regulation catches up — unevenly: The EU AI Act is now in force. US federal regulation will follow, though the timeline is uncertain and sector-specific rules will likely precede comprehensive law. Organizations that have been building responsible AI infrastructure will have an advantage. Those that haven't will face retrofit costs — and some will face regulatory enforcement.

What is genuinely uncertain: - How much cognitive work AI systems can reliably perform, and at what quality threshold - Whether the current AI development trajectory is sustainable (compute costs, energy use, data availability) - Whether concentration of AI capability in a few firms becomes a regulatory and competitive problem - How quickly human adaptation — in skills, organizations, and societies — keeps pace with capability growth

Speaker Notes: Be honest about the uncertainty here. The temptation in a course like this is to end on confident predictions. The intellectually honest position is: the rate of change is high, the direction is mostly clear (agents as infrastructure, regulation arriving, talent gap widening), but the specific shape of the landscape in 5 years is genuinely unknown. What students can do is build the literacy and judgment that makes them valuable across a range of futures, rather than betting everything on one specific scenario. That's the value of conceptual depth over tool familiarity: tools change, frameworks persist.

SLIDE 7 — Discussion: The Question You Carry Out

Title: Open Discussion — 20 Minutes

Three questions, open to the class:

1. "What is the most important thing you changed your mind about in this course?" *(Starting question — lower stakes, opens reflection)*

2. "Where do you think human judgment must be preserved — even when AI is more accurate?" *(The autonomy/accountability question — expect range: some students will say "everywhere," some will say "only where legally required." Both positions deserve engagement.)*

3. "What is the AI deployment decision you would most want to be in the room for, in your career — and why?" *(Forward-looking — connects course learning to professional aspiration)*

Speaker Notes: This is a Socratic discussion, not a lecture. Your role is to ask follow-up questions, surface disagreements, and push past the first answer. For question 2, the most interesting responses are usually the ones that identify a specific context — "I think a human has to make the final call on a medical diagnosis, even if the AI is more accurate, because the patient deserves to have a person accountable for the decision" — or push back on the premise: "I'm not sure preserving human judgment in high-stakes decisions is always good — human judgment has a terrible track record in lending decisions." Both positions are defensible. The goal is not consensus — it's the habit of thinking carefully about where autonomy and accountability belong. Give each question 5–7 minutes. Don't rush to the next question; let the discussion breathe. If a student says something worth pushing on, push on it. This is the last time the class is together in a thinking mode — make it count.

SLIDE 8 — The Capstone: What Happens Tomorrow

Title: AI Innovation Showcase — Session 2 Format

What tomorrow looks like:

Format: Trade show–style. Each team has a station with their demo running. External guests rotate through teams, engage with the demo, ask questions. No formal presentations to the full class — conversations at stations.

Timeline: - Before Session 2: final demo + 3-slide pitch deck submitted via LMS - Session 2 (full session): AI Innovation Showcase

Your 90-second pitch (you'll give it ~6–8 times to different guests): 1. The problem: who has it, what it costs them 2. The AI solution: what your system does, in plain language 3. The responsible AI moment: one risk you identified and one design choice you made to address it

Guest judge questions (from the judge packet): 1. What problem does this solve, and who benefits most? 2. Walk me through what the AI is actually doing in your demo. 3. What could go wrong with this in a real business, and how would you handle it? 4. If you had three more weeks, what would you build next?

Speaker Notes: Walk through the showcase format carefully — some students will not have read the assessments document carefully and will be surprised by the trade show format (as opposed to a formal presentation). The trade show format is intentional: it rewards genuine understanding over rehearsed presentations. You can't memorize your way through 6 rounds of questions from different guests. You have to actually know your work. Remind students: the "responsible AI moment" in the pitch is not optional, and it's worth 15 points. Teams that skip it or address it vaguely are leaving significant grade on the table.

SLIDE 9 — Capstone Prep: The 90-Second Pitch Workshop

Title: Practice Your Pitch — In-Class Exercise (15 minutes)

What you'll do: - Each team prepares their 90-second pitch (problem + solution + responsible AI moment) - One team member delivers it to the instructor; the rest of the team observes - Instructor gives one piece of feedback on clarity, one on the responsible AI moment - Team has 5 minutes to revise before the next team goes

What makes a strong pitch: - The problem is specific. Not "small businesses waste time" but "restaurant owners spend 3 hours per week manually reconciling delivery platform payouts against POS receipts" - The AI solution is described behaviorally. Not "uses AI to help" but "the agent reads the PDF exports from DoorDash and UberEats, extracts the line items, and cross-references them against the POS data — flagging

discrepancies for the owner to review" - The responsible AI moment is concrete. Not "we were careful about privacy" but "the agent never stores customer order data — it processes the reconciliation in memory and discards the inputs after generating the report"

Speaker Notes: Run this as a fast, structured exercise — not open rehearsal time. Set a timer for each team's pitch. Give feedback immediately after. The most common problem you'll see is the AI solution described in abstract terms ("it analyzes and synthesizes data") rather than behavioral terms ("it reads the invoice, extracts the vendor name and amount, compares it to the purchase order in the database, and flags any variance over 5%"). Push hard on this: guests at the showcase will ask "but what does it actually do?" and teams that can't answer that question concretely will struggle. The behavioral description is the test.

SLIDE 10 — The One Sentence

Title: What We Were Really Building

The course objective, restated:

Make you the person in the room who asks the right questions about AI — and knows what to do with the answers.

Seven weeks ago, you came in knowing: → Roughly what AI is

Today, you leave knowing: → How to prompt for decisions, not just drafts → How businesses deploy AI across functions → How to design an agent: goal, tools, memory, reasoning loop, handoffs → How agents fail — and how to design against failure → How to build a working agent from scratch → How to evaluate AI products on strategy, responsible AI, and business model grounds → How to ask: who is harmed, how, at what scale, and what design choice addresses it

That knowledge is transferable, durable, and increasingly rare.

Speaker Notes: This slide is the close of the lecture arc of the course. Deliver it with conviction. The list of what students know is not aspirational — it's accurate. They built an agent. They stress-tested it. They red-teamed another team's product. They pitched an AI-native business. These are things most business professionals have never done. That matters. Don't undersell it.

SLIDE 11 — Final Logistics

Title: Before You Leave Today

Checklist:

☐ **Demo submitted to LMS** before Session 2 (working demo link + 3-slide pitch deck)

☐ **Station setup** — confirm your team knows which station number you've been assigned for the showcase

☐ **90-second pitch** — every team member should be able to deliver it, not just the spokesperson. Guests will ask anyone.

☐ **Responsible AI moment** — have a specific example ready: a risk you identified and a design choice you made. This is in the judge packet.

☐ **"If you had three more weeks" answer** — think about this before tomorrow. It's the last guest question and a great opportunity to show strategic thinking beyond the build.

☐ **Reflection Post 4** — due before this session (already submitted for most students, but confirm)

Speaker Notes: Go through this list item by item. The most frequently missed item is the "every team member can pitch" requirement — teams often assign one spokesperson and everyone else goes silent when a guest asks them a question directly. Guests are instructed to engage the whole team, not just the spokesperson. Every team member needs to be able to explain what the agent does and respond to the responsible AI question. Remind teams of this explicitly.

SLIDE 12 — Close

Title: See You at the Showcase

What we built over seven weeks: Not just tools. Not just vocabulary. A way of thinking about AI that is grounded, specific, and critical — and that will keep working as the technology changes.

What tomorrow is: A chance to show that thinking to people who are making real decisions about AI in real businesses. That's not a class exercise. That's a professional opportunity.

My ask: Show up proud of what you built. Be honest about what it can't do. Answer the hard questions. That combination — confidence in your work, honesty about its limits — is exactly what responsible AI deployment looks like in practice.

Good luck.

Speaker Notes: Short close. The class is ready for tomorrow — they've been building toward it for seven weeks. Don't overstay the moment. End on "Good luck" and mean it.

ACTIVITY PLAN

Activity: Socratic Discussion + Pitch Workshop (20 min discussion + 15 min pitch practice)

Purpose: Close the lecture arc of the course with genuine intellectual engagement on the strategic and ethical questions that persist beyond the course content. Then shift into direct capstone preparation by workshopping each team's 90-second pitch with live instructor feedback.

Part 1: Socratic Discussion (20 minutes)

Setup: No slides displayed during discussion. Instructor sits or stands in a position that signals conversation, not lecture. The three questions on Slide 7 are the structure — don't deviate.

Facilitation notes:

Question 1 — "What did you change your mind about?" Opens reflection without threat. Expect first answers to be safe ("I thought AI was smarter than it is" or "I didn't realize how much the prompt mattered"). Push past the first layer: "What did you believe before? What changed it?" The best answers describe a specific moment — often from the build sprint or the failure mode analysis. Let those stories breathe.

Question 2 — "Where must human judgment be preserved?" This is the ethical core of the discussion. Common student positions: - "Anywhere a person's life is significantly affected" — healthcare, criminal justice, employment - "Anywhere we can't explain the decision" — pushes on the explainability problem - "Nowhere — human judgment is biased and AI is more consistent" — this position deserves genuine engagement, not dismissal. The response is not "but AI is biased too" (true but not decisive) — it's "what do we lose when no

human is accountable for the decision, even if the decision is better?" Your goal is to surface the tension, not resolve it. If the class converges too quickly on a comfortable answer, push: "Is there anyone who disagrees?"

Question 3 — "What AI decision would you want to be in the room for?" Forward-looking and revealing. Students who say "I want to be in the room when a company decides whether to deploy a hiring AI" are drawn to governance. Students who say "when a hospital system decides to let an agent triage patients" are drawn to high-stakes product. Students who say "when a startup decides which use case to build first" are entrepreneurially oriented. Use this to reflect back what you've observed about the class: "I'm not surprised you said that — your capstone showed exactly that kind of thinking."

Part 2: Pitch Workshop (15 minutes)

Structure: each team delivers their 90-second pitch to the instructor. One piece of feedback on clarity of the AI solution description. One piece of feedback on the responsible AI moment. Teams have 5 minutes to revise. If time permits, one team does a second run.

Common feedback patterns: - "What does the AI actually do?" — behavioral description is almost always too abstract on first draft - "What's the responsible AI moment?" — teams often describe a general concern rather than a specific design choice. Push: "What changed in your build because of this risk?" - "Why does this person care?" — some problem statements lack specificity about who is affected and at what scale. "Small businesses" is not a person. "A restaurant owner managing three locations who reconciles payouts manually every Sunday night" is.

Pacing: With 5+ teams, 15 minutes is tight. Keep feedback to 2 sentences per team, per criterion. Speed is the discipline — teams get more useful feedback from 5 fast rounds than from 2 long ones.

Materials needed: - Slide 7 (discussion questions) available but not displayed during discussion - Timer visible during pitch workshop - Capstone submission checklist (Slide 11) displayed after pitch workshop